

A recent line of decisions, however, has resolved that ambiguity, at least to the following extent: at an irreducible minimum, Art. III requires the party who invokes the court's authority to "show that he personally has suffered some actual or threatened injury as a result of the putatively illegal conduct of the defendant," *Gladstone, Realtors v. Village of Bellwood*, 441 U. S. 91, 99 (1979), and that the injury "fairly can be traced to the challenged action" and "is likely to be redressed by a favorable decision," *Simon v. Eastern Kentucky Welfare Rights Org.*, 426 U. S. 26, 38, 41 (1976).⁹ In this manner does Art. III limit the federal judicial power "to those disputes which confine federal courts to a role consistent with a system of separated powers and which are traditionally thought to be capable of resolution through the judicial process." *Flast v. Cohen*, 392 U. S., at 97.

The requirement of "actual injury redressable by the court," *Simon*, *supra*, at 39, serves several of the "implicit policies embodied in Article III," *Flast*, *supra*, at 96. It tends to assure that the legal questions presented to the court will be resolved, not in the rarified atmosphere of a debating society, but in a concrete factual context conducive to a realistic appreciation of the consequences of judicial action. The "standing" requirement serves other purposes. Because it assures an actual factual setting in which the litigant asserts a claim of injury in fact, a court may decide the case with some confidence that its decision will not pave the way for lawsuits which have some, but not all, of the facts of the case actually decided by the court.

⁹ See *Watt v. Energy Action Educational Foundation*, *ante*, at 161; *Duke Power Co. v. Carolina Environmental Study Group, Inc.*, 438 U. S. 59, 72 (1978); *Arlington Heights v. Metropolitan Housing Dev. Corp.*, 429 U. S. 252, 261, 262 (1977); *Warth v. Seldin*, 422 U. S. 490, 499 (1975); *Schlesinger v. Reservists Committee to Stop the War*, 418 U. S. 208, 218, 220-221 (1974); *United States v. Richardson*, 418 U. S. 166, 179-180 (1974); *O'Shea v. Littleton*, 414 U. S. 488, 493 (1974); *Linda R. S. v. Richard D.*, 410 U. S. 614, 617-618 (1973).